

The Green One

In a memory of Sergeant Briggs and Blackhoof Witherspine

The screaming had stopped an hour ago, which was almost worse.

Briggs sat on an upturned crate at the edge of the medical tent and watched the goblin surgeons work. *Surgeons* was a generous word for what they were — field butchers with a passing acquaintance with anatomy and no patience for ceremony. One of them was pressing a length of iron heated to dull orange against a soldier's thigh stump, and the smell that came with it was something Briggs had never learned to ignore, no matter how many campaigns he had behind him. The soldier made a sound that was not quite goblin and not quite anything else.

Briggs took a pull from his tin flask and looked away.

The tent held eleven men. Half (hopefully lesser half) of them would be dead before morning, by his estimate — not from the wounds themselves but from what the surgeons would do to fix them. He had seen it before. A man could survive a blade in the gut only to die of the cure: the rusty needle dragging gut-thread through torn flesh, the amputated arm taken too high when it should have come off at the wrist.

He had walked out of the valley without a scratch.

He was not sure whether that made him lucky or simply careful, and he had stopped examining the question too closely. Luck was a thing other men trusted. Briggs preferred sight-lines and the habit of standing behind something solid.

Still. He looked at the tent again and felt something that was not quite relief settle heavy in his chest. Unheroic. Unglamorous. But he was breathing, and the man on the table was not making sounds anymore, which meant he had either passed out or stopped, and Briggs made himself not think too hard about which.

He drank again and waited for whatever came next.

He heard them before he saw them.

The sound of hooves on hard-packed earth, like distant thunder. Briggs recognized it immediately. He closed his flask, pushed himself off the crate, and walked toward the sound without hurrying. There was never any point in hurrying toward the thing you already knew was coming.

The supply officer — a wiry goblin named Tusk who wore his rank-marks on a chain around his neck because he had long since run out of coat left to pin them to — was standing at the edge of the main path with a folded ledger under his arm and an expression of professional satisfaction.

Twelve of them.

They came in from the eastern track in a loose column, and they were exactly what Briggs had expected: young, broad-shouldered, coats brushed and gleaming in the pale afternoon sun, armour oiled, blades sheathed but eager. They held their heads up. All of them. That was the tell — that particular angle of chin that came from recruiters who had spent months telling young men that they were going to be the finest cavalry the goblin armies had ever fielded, that glory was a thing you could ride toward and catch, that the stories



they'd heard since childhood were waiting for them just beyond the next treeline.

Briggs had worn that expression once.

He could not quite remember when he had stopped.

Tusk spotted him and waved him over with the ledger. Briggs crossed the distance between the medical tent and the supply officer with the unhurried stride.

"Sergeant." Tusk flipped open the ledger. "We heard you lost your mount in the valley."

"Mm."

"Fell covering your retreat, the report says."

Briggs said nothing. *My retreat* was not how he would have described it. *A tactical repositioning under heavy fire* would have been more accurate, but the report was written by someone who had not been there, and correcting paperwork was a battle Briggs had given up on years ago.

"Anyway." Tusk gestured at the twelve with his ledger. "You've got first pick, as is your rank. Choose yours, then tell me the order for your men."

Briggs looked at the twelve young centaurs.

They looked back at him — bright-eyed, radiating the particular energy of young soldiers.

He reached into his coat pocket.

Tusk blinked. "What are you—"

Briggs produced a twelve-sided die, worn smooth from years in his pocket, and rolled it against the flat of his palm. It bounced once and settled.

Three. He rolled again. Odd. He counted from the left.

"That one," he said.

"That's Blackhoof, fines of the Witherspine bree... stables!" gulped Tusk, with the tone of a man who had introduced a great many young soldiers to a great many sergeants and had learned not to editorialize.

The centaur who stepped forward was — Briggs observed, with the dispassion of a man cataloguing supplies — well-presented. The armour was old, clearly taken from a predecessor, but every strap had been oiled and every buckle squared. The blade at his hip sat correctly in its scabbard. His coat was clean. He came to attention with a precision that suggested he had been practising it.

He was also, Briggs noted, approximately the age of a bad idea.

Blackhoof saluted — a sharp, correct movement, textbook — and stood waiting with the expression of someone who had rehearsed this moment and intended to perform it properly.

Briggs looked at him for a long moment. Not unkindly, but without warmth. The look of a man taking an accurate measurement.

He turned back to Tusk.

"How long before the next push?"

Tusk consulted his ledger. "You move at dawn tomorrow."

Briggs looked at him.

"Tomorrow," he repeated.

"First light."

"I haven't had ten minutes with him yet, let alone enough to teach him anything worth knowing. Give us three days, minimum. A week would be—"

"Tomorrow morning, Sergeant." Tusk closed the ledger with the finality of someone who considered the matter settled. "Command's orders. Not mine." He tucked the ledger under his arm and walked away with the efficiency of a man whose job was to deliver information, not to receive complaints about it.

Briggs watched him go.

He opened his flask, found it empty, and looked at it for a moment with the expression of a man confirming a suspicion he had already held.

Then he turned back to Blackhoof, who was still standing at attention, still correct, still waiting — bright-eyed and gleaming-armoured and entirely unaware of what dawn tomorrow was going to ask of him.

"Well," said Briggs. "Stand easy before you hurt yourself."

Briggs didn't waste time on ceremony.

Don't, he thought, somewhere behind his eyes. *Don't bother. You know how this ends.*

He had known too many of them. Each one eager, each one gleaming, each one absolutely certain that the stories were true. He took a pull from the flask and got to work.

"Your head," he said. "You carry it too high. Chin up, throat open. In a press, the first thing a pike finds is the gap under the jaw." He tapped his own throat once, briefly. "Tuck it. Not down — in. Keep the angle. You want to see forward, not advertise yourself."

Blackhoof adjusted. Correct on the first try. Briggs noted this without expression.

"When I ride, I sit behind your shoulders. You'll feel the weight and you'll want to compensate — lean right, open your left flank." He moved to Blackhoof's side and placed a hand flat on his shoulder, a brief, impersonal contact. "Don't. I'll balance myself. Your job is the ground. Let me worry about the saddle."

"Yes, Sergeant."

"The ground." Briggs crouched and looked at Blackhoof's hooves with the expression of a man reading a document. "Left rear. You favour it on the turn — I saw it when you came in. On wet ground, that's a fall. On a slope, it's worse." He straightened. "Tomorrow morning, before we move: check it. Pack the frog if it's soft. Don't tell me about it, just do it."

Blackhoof was quiet for a moment. He had been waiting — without quite admitting it to himself — for something else. A word about the fight ahead. The honour of it, the purpose of it. Something like the speeches the recruiters gave, all firelight and raised fists.

What he had received was a lesson in geometry.

"Is that everything?" he asked, and tried to keep the flatness out of his voice.

Briggs looked at him. Just looked, for a moment, the way he looked at the hooves — reading something.

"That's everything useful," he said, and walked away to find his bedroll.

The grey came before the sun did.

Briggs was already up, moving through the camp with the quiet efficiency of a man who had learned not to sleep through dawns. He came to Blackhoof without announcement and walked around him once, checking the buckles, the straps, the angle of the blade, the left rear hoof — centaur had packed it, and Briggs examined the work and said nothing, which was answer enough.

He came around to the front and looked up at the young centaur's face. Blackhoof was standing straight, chin correctly tucked, throat covered. Armour squared. Ready.

"Don't get killed in the first five minutes," he said. "Everything after that is learnable."

He turned away and swung himself up into the saddle.

Across the camp, the horn sounded — one long note that flattened the morning air and sent men moving. The treeline was just beginning to separate from the sky, dark shapes becoming trees, the first thin light deciding to arrive.

Blackhoof moved forward, and Briggs ready, neither of them said another word as the column formed around them and the dawn came up red over the ridge.